

Digital cameras

So many models, so much variety, which one to choose?

It's the start of yet another year and turning to photography as a hobby might be a good idea. There are so many cameras in the market, but which one do you opt for? There's just too much to choose from. All throughout the year, we emphasise on cameras in articles and tests.

Going shopping for a camera is first about doing your homework and being very clear on what you want from it. Most people purchase standard point-and-shoot cameras that are priced anywhere between Rs. 7,000 to Rs. 15,000. The grey market prices are obviously going to be lower. The entry-level PowerShot A470 from Canon is still available at just under Rs. 7,000. The PowerShot A1000 IS and the very new A2000 IS have just been released in the market for a little over Rs. 11,000. They are 10-MP cameras with 4x and 6x optical zoom lenses.

Canon has been updating the PowerShot line of cameras up the price scale as well. The well-known Canon PowerShot A720 IS and the A650 IS are mid-ranged P&S cameras to own. The prices of these in the market hover somewhere between Rs. 11,000 mark in the grey market. These cameras both come with 6x optical zoom which is sufficient for most purposes. If you want something a bit cheaper, then the PowerShot A590 IS is one to look for. The price of the A590 IS has dropped to around Rs. 11,500.

However, if you want a no-compromise P&S camera with a good zoom lens and a decent-sized sensor, the

new SX110 is the one to look for. It has a better build and is a better performer than the older SX100. Priced at around Rs. 16,000, it comes with a pouch and a 2 GB SD card. Look out for schemes in malls and showrooms where you get a charger and batteries along with the camera.

There are a few new ultrazoom cameras in the market too. The DSC H7 and H9 from Sony come with 15x optical zoom. Canon's S5 IS is still in the market and can be found at around Rs.

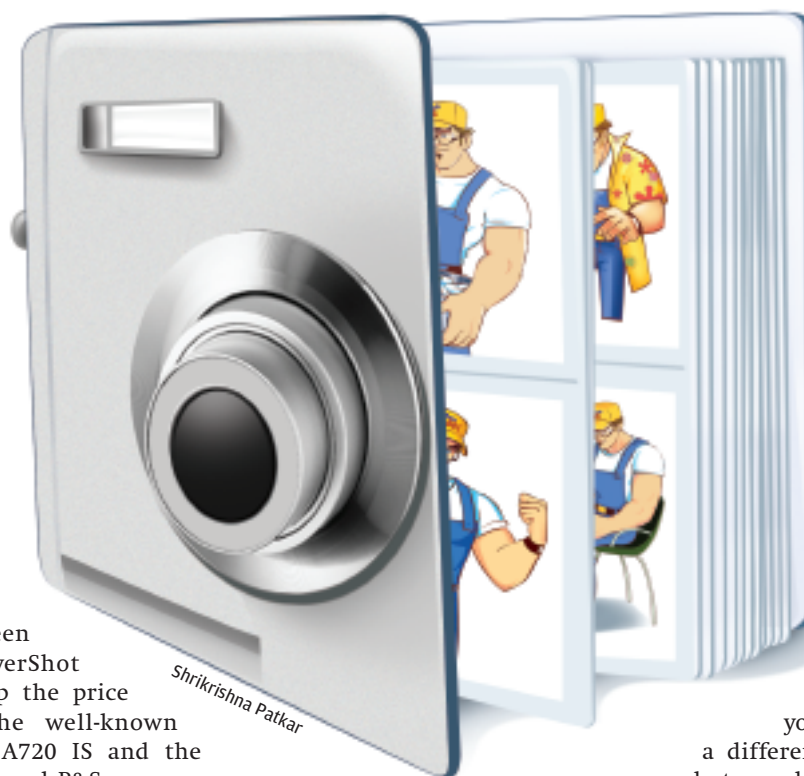
priced under Rs. 15,000. Even the Nikon S52 is available for just under Rs. 13,000. Clearly, the days of extremely expensive ultracompacts have passed. Even Sony's T77 is not more than Rs. 16,000 in the market.

One of the more interesting categories of cameras is the D-SLR. Prices have dropped and are now just above the price bracket for the ultracompact fashion oriented cameras. The Nikon D40 and the D40X are the entry-level offering from Nikon. Rumours are that the D40 is priced around Rs. 18,000 in the grey market, but that's only great if you can find one. If you can't, then the D40X is the next best bet. The Nikon D60 has been brought in to replace the D40 and the D40X. Canon has a few entry-level D-SLR cameras too — the EOS 1000D and the EOS 400D. Both of these cameras can be bought for around Rs. 30,000 to Rs. 33,000. The lens supplied with most of these cameras is the 18-55 mm ones. Look out for shops that sell you only the body and give

you the option of selecting a different lens. Shopkeepers and photographers will also tell you that cost of Canon lens is considerably more than the Nikon ones.

This month, we reviewed the Nikon D90 and liked it a lot. We suggest you look out for a Nikon D80. The D90 replaces the D80, which might get phased out soon. The prices for the D80 have been dropping steadily with the launch of the D90. The D80 body itself in the grey market is rumoured to be around Rs. 35,000 and there are some interesting offers for lenses offered as well. ☐

agent001@thinkdigit.com



Shrikrishna Patkar

17,000. Canon has begun to phase them out with the SX10 which has an incredible 20x optical zoom as compared to the S5 IS' 12x. If you like to go for an Olympus ultrazoom, then the SP565UZ is an interesting model to look out for. The price is somewhere around Rs. 20,000.

Compact cameras are available at under Rs. 15,000 as well. They aren't typically liked for performance but for size and portability reasons. The IXUS 80 and 85 IS are the ones from Canon

Q I want an HDTV. The screen size doesn't matter much. Even a 22-inch is sufficient. But I would like to buy at least a 26-inch TV. The main thing is the resolution of that TV, because I own an Xbox 360 console and I want to play games in HD. It should have at least one HDMI port. I'm looking to buy a Samsung-LA22A450C1 only because it has a higher resolution (1680 x 1050). However, other TVs in this price range offer lower resolution (1366 x 768) and are priced even higher. Is it the right decision to buy that Samsung TV? My budget is upto Rs. 30,000.

Jatin Mongia

A In my opinion, for playing games on a console, your screen size would be more important than all other considerations. Since most large-screen displays support a resolution of at least 1366 x 768, I think you're well covered by even a 22-inch LCD monitor for a PC. Dell's SP 2208 WFP is a 22-inch monitor with an HDMI-port priced at Rs. 15,000. The option from Samsung that you are looking at is also good. Remember that these are PC monitors as their resolutions are most commonly found on PCs and not LCD TVs, as TV-based displays have resolutions of 720p, 1366 x 768 pixels or 1080p. If you're looking at a 26-inch LCD monitor with a high resolution, look at ViewSonic's VP 2650 wb with a native resolution of 1920 x 1200 pixels and priced at Rs. 27,000.

Q I'm using my computer for last ten years. Now it has become old. So I want to purchase a new one with the latest components. My hobby is photography, and I have a Canon PowerShot SX100IS Digital camera. I need components suitable for photography, audio-video and games. I want to purchase a 19-inch LCD monitor, web camera and printer. Please recommend components that will complement my hobbies. My budget is Rs. 50,000.

Ashok R Naik

A That is a good budget and you will notice a manifold increase in performance from your current setup. I have suggested a system for you below. I suggest you opt for a 22-inch monitor. The Rs. 3,000 or so more you pay, is worth it.

PC Configuration		
Components	My Suggestion	Price
Processor	Core 2 Duo E8400 (3.0 GHz)	8,500
Motherboard	Abit IP35E	4,800
RAM	1 x 4 GB DDR2 800 MHz	3,800
Graphics Card	ZOTAC 9800 GTX	10,500
Hard Drive	Seagate 500 GB	3,100
Monitor	Dell SP 2208 WFP	15,500
Cabinet + PSU	VIP Cabinet + 500W SMPS	3,500
		49,700

Q I am thinking buying a cellphone priced between Rs. 8,000 to Rs. 9,000. I want features like a

music player, good camera (3MP) and software loading with a decent look.

Harsimran Rangri

A Sony Ericsson's K800 might be what you're looking for. It's priced at Rs. 8,000 or so, and with great music quality and a superb 3.2-MP camera, it may be just what you're looking for. The only other phone that comes to mind is the Nokia N73 and that is beyond your budget.

Q I have got Intel 945 chipset motherboard (original), 1GB DDR2 RAM. I want a graphics card for gaming, within a budget of Rs. 8,000. Will my motherboard support a PCIe video card? Which card would suit me?

Nilanjan Roy

A Yes, the Intel 945 board should support a PCIe card with the requisite slot. I recommend a 9600 GT-based solution. EVGA is a good brand to look at and it should fit your budget. If you can stretch your budget to Rs. 2,000 to Rs 3,000, you might be able to go in for a GeForce 9800 GTX or a Radeon 4850 which are far superior cards.

Q I want to buy a powerful gaming rig under a lakh. It will be used only for gaming. Please suggest a powerful configuration. I also want to buy a multimedia cellphone. I can spare Rs. 35,000 for a cellphone. Which is better between a Nokia N96 and an Apple iPhone?

Kshitij Rawat

PC Configuration		
Components	My Suggestion	Price
Processor	Core 2 Quad Q9550 (2.83 GHz)	17,500
Motherboard	ASUS P5Q-E	10,000
RAM	1 x 4 GB DDR2 800	3,800
Graphics Card	ZOTAC GTX 280	30,000
Hard Drive	Seagate 500 GB x 2	6,000
Monitor	LG 246 Wp	24,000
Cabinet + PSU	CM 690 + Corsair TX 750	9,500
		1,00,800

A For the cellphone, I recommend Nokia for the usability and the iPhone 3G for its touch interface. They're both good enough to recommend. Either way you cannot go wrong. Although I must say, Nokia's N96 is the more perfect device of the two, especially when it comes to being a feature-laden phone. For a PC, my recommendations are given in the box.

Alternatively, you can opt for a Palit Radeon HD 4870 1GB SONIC, priced at Rs. 18,500 instead of the ZOTAC GTX 280. This card offers amazing value for money, and you can actually buy another identical card and CrossFire both of them for even more performance, although you would compromise on your budget. ☐